28 OCTOBER 2026

WESTPAC–DATAX CARD TRACKER

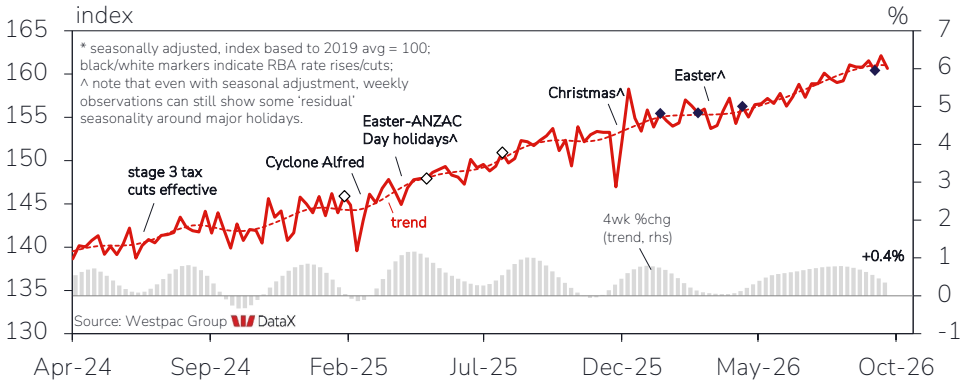
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Card activity showing robust growth but with a mixed start to October

- The **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index*** has edged down slightly since late September, slipping 0.9pts to 160.6 in the week ended October 17. Despite this, growth in activity continues to track a robust pace with quarterly momentum running at close to 2%qtr and annual growth at 6%yr.
- Some of this reflects revisions. Initial figures on card activity can see changes in subsequent weeks due to information lags. While these are usually small, the cumulative impact can sometimes be material. In this case, revisions have lifted the index in late September by 2.5pts and the 4wk trend growth rate at the time from 0.2% to 0.6%. We will be back-testing regular revisions to assess whether there is a systematic bias that can be adjusted for in future.
- The revised profile shows quarterly growth accelerating steadily since June, posting a 1.9%qtr gain for the September quarter and tracking a 2.1%qtr pace in the latest week. This is back near the robust pace seen in late 2024 and early 2025.
- The monthly and weekly reads show a softer 0.2%mth rise in August was followed by a solid 0.8%mth gain in September that has largely carried into the first two weeks of October (the latest observation tracking a 0.4%mth pace).
- The detail shows gains are not just due to higher fuel prices with strong growth in discretionary services and international transactions over the last quarter and steady growth in essential services as well. To the extent that the weekly and monthly data is showing some renewed squeeze from higher fuel prices, this is showing through most clearly in discretionary goods, which have seen activity decline over the last six weeks, with discretionary services still posting positive, albeit slower growth. Quarterly growth in non-fuel card activity is tracking around 1.4%qtr.
- Official September quarter figures on inflation and household spending due in the coming weeks should confirm the spending momentum and shed more light on the extent to which it is due to prices or volumes.

"... quarterly momentum running at close to 2%qtr ..."

1. Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index*



The **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker** presents indicators based on the millions of credit and debit card transactions processed by Westpac every day. The measures are a timely guide to shifts in spending. See p10 for a detailed explanation.

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This issue was finalised on 28 October 2026.

If you would like more insights on your sector or business from this and other Westpac data please visit Westpac DataX or contact datax@westpac.com.au.

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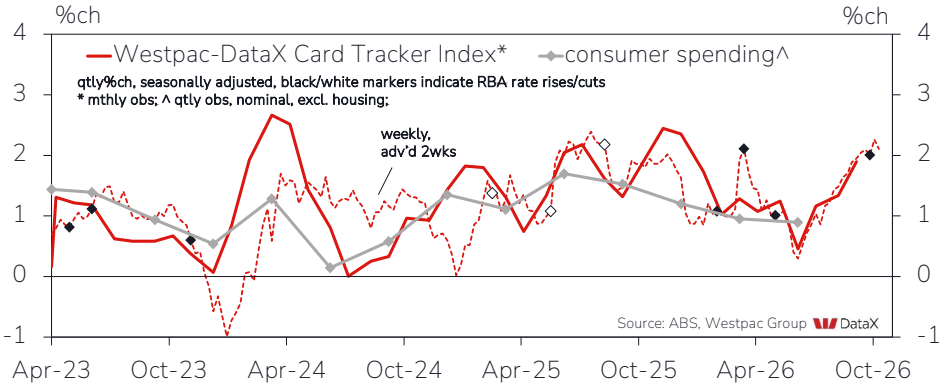
Quarterly momentum softening ex fuel, about flat since July

- Chart 2 shows how quarterly growth in the **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index** compares to growth in nominal consumption as reported in the national accounts. Growth has shown a clear acceleration since late June, lifting to 1.9%qtr in the September quarter and running at 2.1%qtr in the latest week. Weekly reads in early October have been the strongest since July 2025.
- Only some of this reflects a price-driven rise in fuel spend. The unwind of temporary fuel excise tax cuts in August and more recent surge in global energy prices has seen local pump prices push back above $2.40/litre locally, up from $1.56/litre in late June.
- Excluding fuel, quarterly growth in card activity has moderated, but only slightly, from 1.9%qtr in August to 1.8% in September with the latest week tracking a 1.4% quarterly pace. The impact is more pronounced in monthly terms with a –0.4%mth decline in August, muted +0.2% gain in September and subdued +0.1% monthly pace in the latest week (c.f. total: –0.4%; +0.2% and +0.1%).
- The 1.9%qtr rise in nominal terms and an expected price rise of 1.1%qtr point to a real, inflation-adjusted gain of 0.8%qtr, in line with Westpac's forecasts. ABS Q3 CPI figures are due shortly after we go to press with the Q3 household spending indicator due Nov 4 and GDP due Dec 2.

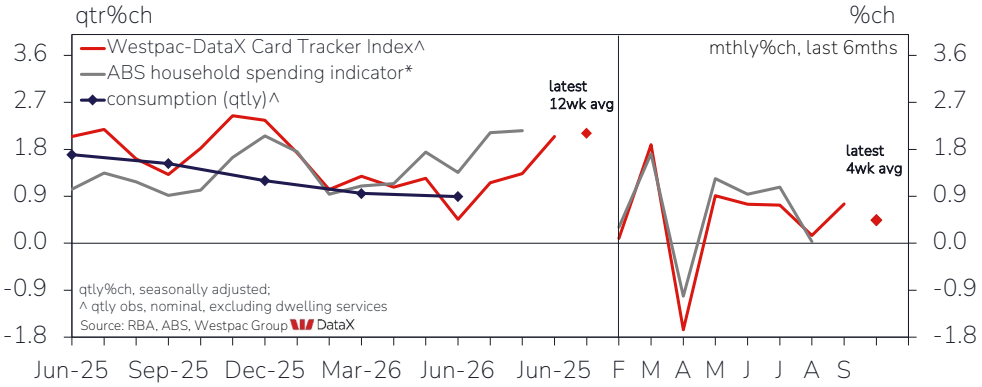
qtly%ch	Q1	Q2	Q3	latest^
Westpac–DataX Card Tracker	**1.3**	**0.5**	**1.9**	**2.1**
ABS monthly household spending indicator*				
Nominal	1.1	1.4	n.a.	2.2
Real*	0.8	0.7	n.a.	n.a.
ABS consumer spending (qtly)#				
Nominal	1.0	0.9	n.a.	n.a.
Real	0.4	0.4	n.a.	n.a.

All series seasonally adjusted. Latest is either the latest weekly obs (12wks %ch on previous 12wks) or latest monthly obs (3mths %ch on previous 3mths). See p10 for more details.
* ABS monthly household spending indicator based on domestic card transaction and new vehicle sales data. Real estimates are quarterly.
Consumer spending excludes housing costs.
Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

2. Card activity and spending: growth momentum



3. Consumer spending: selected indicators



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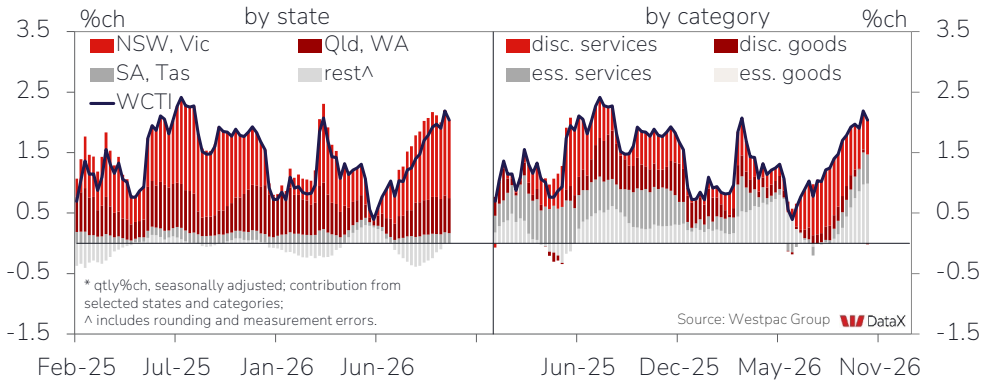
Services still relatively strong; discretionary goods flat-lining

- Chart 4 shows quarterly growth in card activity broken down by contributions from major state and category groups.
- The contribution from essential goods captures the effect of fuel price swings. Outside of this, discretionary services have been the main driver of growth with solid support coming from essential services. Discretionary goods activity has essentially stalled flat. In quarterly growth terms, essential goods is now leading, running at 3.6%qtr (+0.9%qtr ex fuel), with essential services tracking at 2.5%qtr, discretionary services running at 2.0%qtr and discretionary goods much weaker at –0.1%qtr (down materially in per capita terms).
- By state, the large south eastern states of NSW and Vic account for nearly two thirds of the growth.
- As noted, the latest update includes significant revisions. Data lags and cleaning often result in shifts to historical estimates. These are typically small but can be have a material cumulative effect. Chart 5 shows the impact of the latest revision: for the last week of September, it lifts the WCTI 2.5pts and the 4wk trend growth rate from 0.2% to 0.6%, removing what looked to be a slowing in momentum at the time. We will be investigating this issue more closely in coming weeks to see whether there is a systematic bias that can be adjusted for in the future.

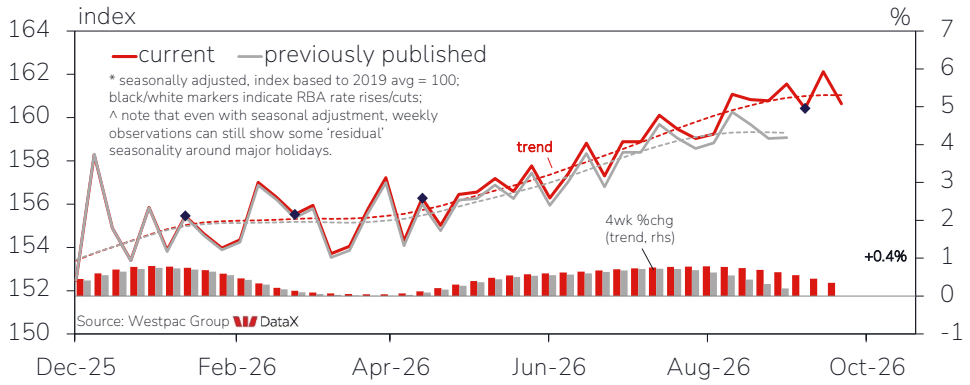
	Jul	Aug	Sep	17/10
Westpac–DataX Card Tracker	**158.3**	**158.6**	**159.8**	**160.6**
By category				
– discretionary*	160.6	159.9	160.6	160.7
– essential*	153.0	153.9	155.7	158.0
By state				
– NSW	151.4	151.4	153.8	154.6
– Vic	149.1	150.0	150.7	154.9
– Qld	173.5	173.8	174.8	178.7
– WA	175.8	177.1	179.5	181.7
– SA	165.3	166.7	168.5	168.6

All indexes based on the value of spending–related transactions, seasonally adjusted, 2019 avg=100, see p10 for more details including classifications.
* indexes revised due to re-classification.
Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

4. Card activity: contributions by state and category



5. Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index: revision



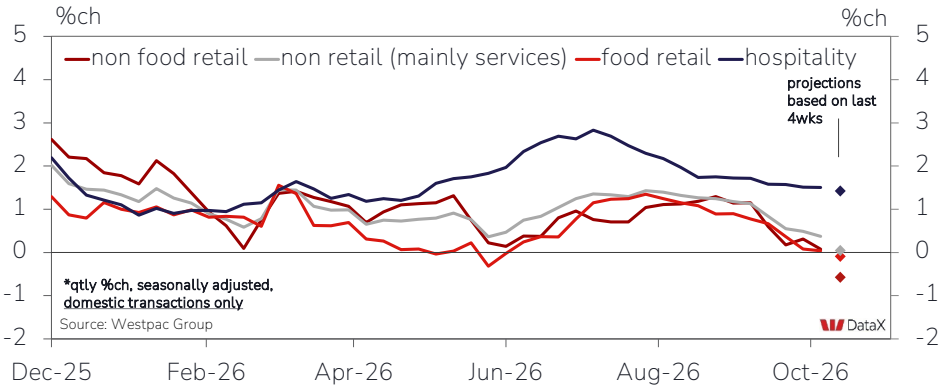
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Retail more exposed to softer consumer segments

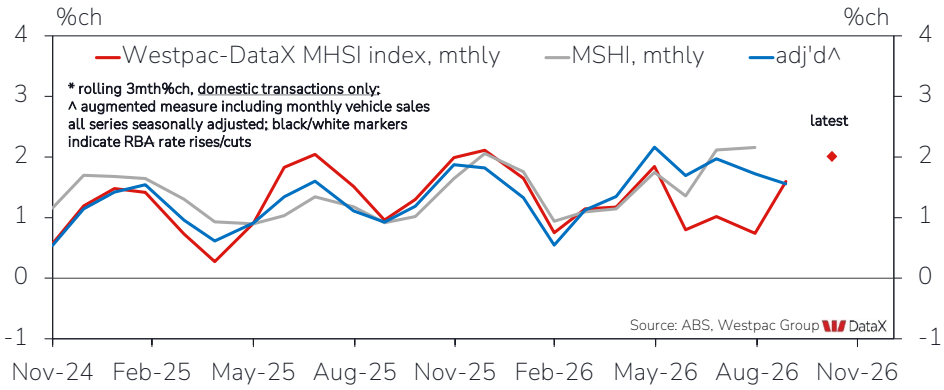
- Our MHSI and retail card indexes are composite measures based on transactions in categories that are in scope for the ABS monthly household spending indicator (MHSI) and retail sales estimates (which have been based on the MHSI detail since the ABS retail survey was discontinued in June 2025).
- After under-performing the broader WCTI in Q2, the MHSI index has moved more in line in Q3, posting growth of 1.6%qtr with the latest week running at 2%qtr. The retail card index has been more subdued, up 1.1%qtr in Q3, growth running at just 0.4%qtr in the latest week.
- The ABS MHSI has been firmer than our index since June, mainly reflecting strong gains in vehicle sales which are not incorporated into our index. Vehicle sales appear to have been relatively flat in recent months, our estimates suggesting the official measure, due Nov 4, should show quarterly growth more in line with our indicator (Chart 7).
- The more granular detail on the retail card index shows non-food retail contracting materially over the last four weeks, consistent with the weakness being observed across discretionary goods categories.

	Jul	Aug	Sep	17/10
MHSI card index	**155.3**	**155.3**	**157.0**	**158.6**
– qtly%ch	1.0	0.7	1.6	2.0
– qtly, ann%ch	5.2	5.4	5.8	5.7
ABS MHSI				
– %ch	1.1	0.0	n.a.	n.a.
– qtly%ch	2.1	2.2	n.a.	n.a.
– qtly ann%ch	6.2	7.0	n.a.	n.a.
Retail card index	**155.7**	**155.1**	**155.4**	**155.1**
– qtly%ch	1.8	1.3	1.1	0.4
– qtly, ann%ch	5.6	5.3	5.0	4.2
ABS retail sales				
– %ch	1.0	-0.2	n.a.	n.a.
– qtly%ch	1.8	1.5	n.a.	n.a.
– qtly ann%ch	5.5	5.6	n.a.	n.a.

6. Card activity: retail segments and non-retail



7. Card activity: ABS MHSI index vs WCTI measures

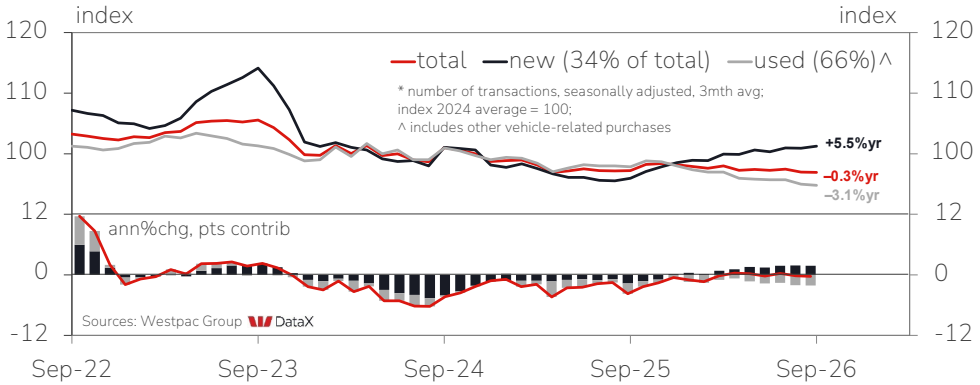


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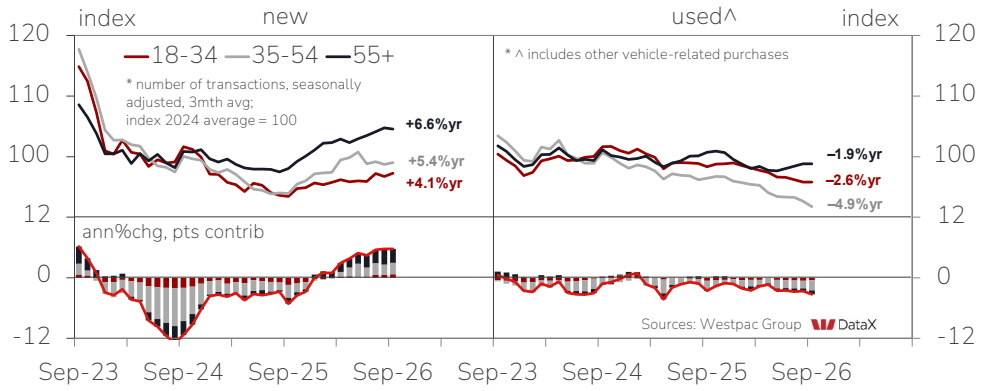
Vehicle-related card activity highlights diverging trends

- The **Westpac Card Tracker** draws on a rich dataset that sheds light on many aspects of consumer demand. In some cases, it can also reveal some nuances about the way spend is captured – in official statistics, industry measures and the card data itself. Vehicles provide a particularly good example of this.
- Vehicle spend has long been a bellwether for the wider consumer cycle. As a large discretionary expenditure, it is more sensitive to interest rate changes, 'wealth effects' and sentiment shifts, particularly around job security. Given this, ABS measures and industry figures on vehicle sales have delivered material upside surprises over the last year. Vehicle purchases recorded a remarkable 10.3%qtr surge in the June quarter to be up 7.3%yr with industry figures showing vehicle sales holding around these levels in the September quarter. Even allowing 'extenuating circumstances' driving strong demand for EVs, the results seem to fly in the face of wider interest rate, cost-of-living and sentiment narratives.
- The card tracker data allows for a deeper dive. Note that credit and debit cards are not often used to purchase vehicles with account transfers or financing typically used for the main purchase instead.
- However, cards are used for up-front payments. This shows through in payment sizes, which are in the hundreds of dollars (average $750) not the tens of thousands. As such, card activity should still give some guide, particularly around sales volumes.
- Chart 8 shows how transactions have tracked and highlight another important point. Most of the data in this space focuses on new vehicles (for the ABS this is because used sales are a transfer between households that 'cancels out' for the sector as a whole). However, industry estimates show used sales are both more common and have been tracking a weaker profile – the card data suggests used sales are down at least 3%yr (finer estimates putting the figure closer to 8%yr).
- Age-groups offer another insightful lens. Activity has been much firmer across older age groups, particularly in the 'new vehicle' segment where they are more prominent (accounting for 42% of all activity) and activity is up on a year ago. This group has notably stronger balance sheets and is low exposure to interest rate rises. In contrast, vehicle spend has been contracting materially across other age-groups, particularly used car spend by the 'mortgage belt' 35-54 year olds.

8. Card activity: vehicles

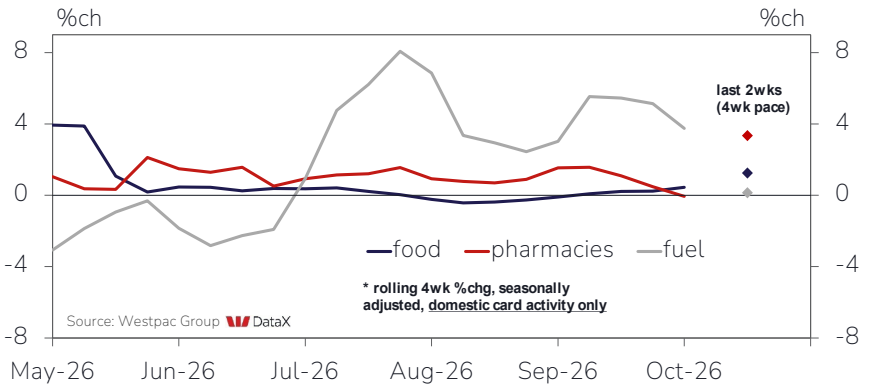


9. Card activity: new, used vehicles by age group

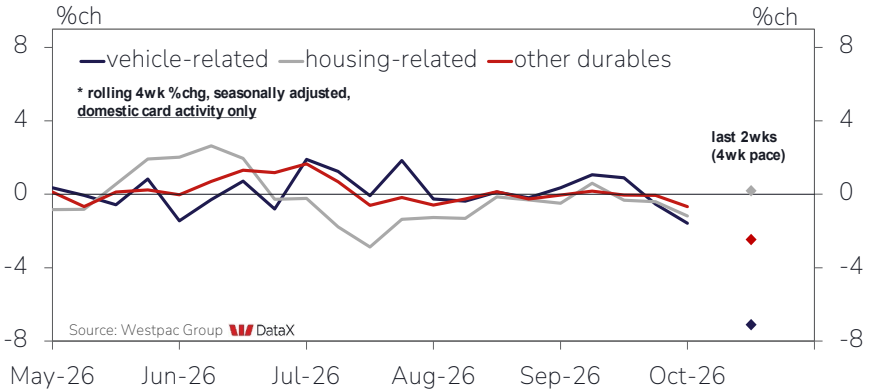


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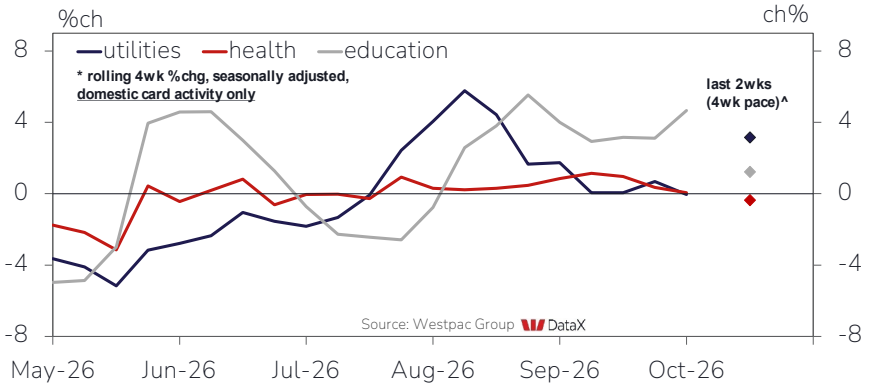
10. Card activity: essential goods



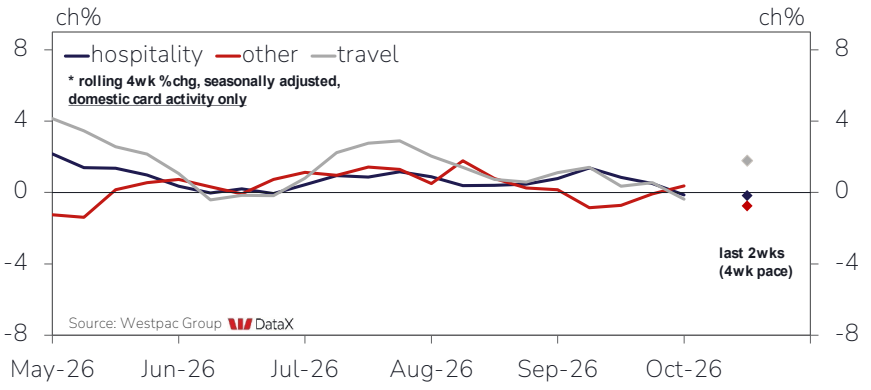
11. Card activity: discretionary goods



12. Card activity: essential services

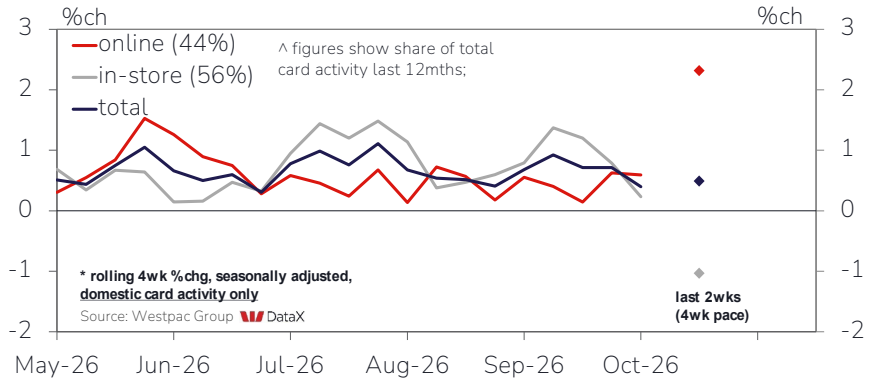


13. Card activity: discretionary services

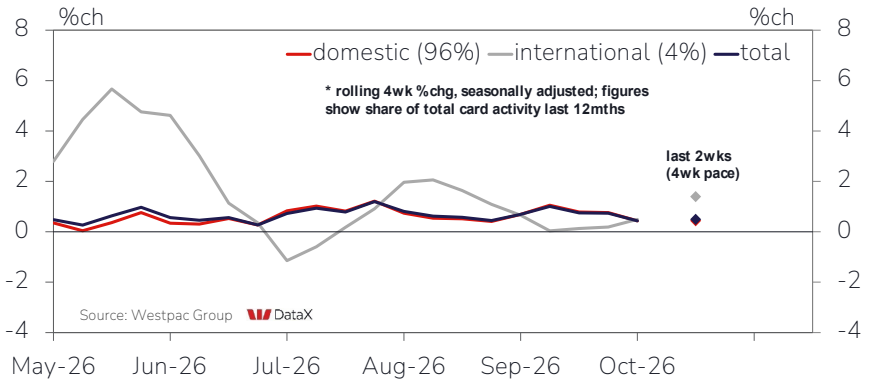


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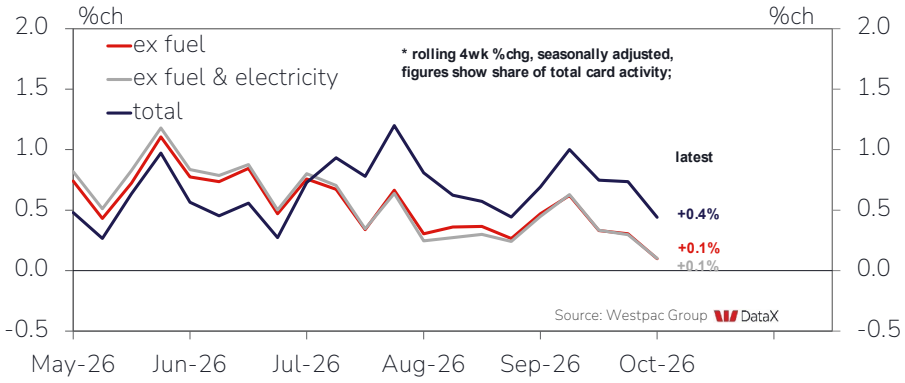
14. Card activity: online and in-store



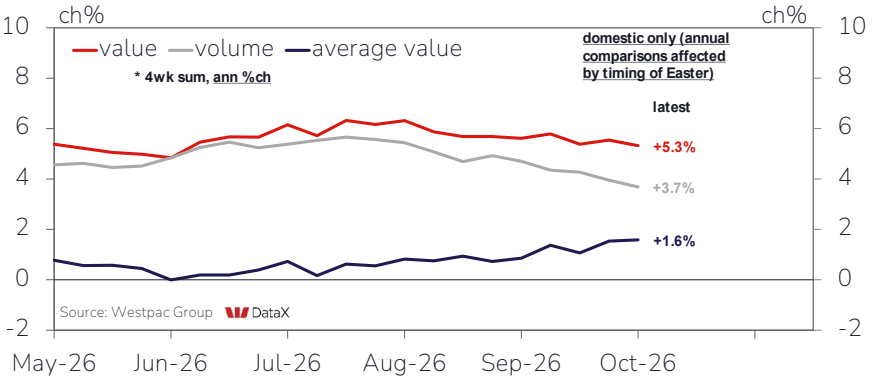
15. Card activity: food and non-food



16. Card activity: total, ex fuel and electricity



17. Card activity: value and volume



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WESTPAC CARD INDICATORS*

	2024		2025			2026					week ending:				
	Q4	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Q3	Jul	Aug	Sep	26/9	3/10	10/10	17/10
Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index	**143.0**	**144.8**	**147.8**	**149.7**	**153.3**	**155.2**	**155.9**	**158.9**	**158.3**	**158.6**	**159.8**	**161.6**	**160.4**	**162.1**	**160.6**
qtly%ch	1.4	1.3	2.0	1.3	2.4	1.3	0.5	1.9	1.2	1.3	1.9	2.1	2.0	2.3	2.1
qtly, ann%ch	5.3	3.9	5.2	6.2	7.2	7.2	5.5	6.1	5.9	6.2	6.1	6.1	6.0	6.0	6.0
By category															
– discretionary	145.7	146.1	149.3	151.3	155.2	155.9	157.2	160.4	160.6	159.9	160.6	162.3	161.7	163.4	160.7
– essential	138.4	141.4	144.0	145.9	148.2	151.4	151.9	154.2	153.0	153.9	155.7	158.6	156.7	158.4	158.0
services	150.5	152.8	156.6	159.6	163.3	164.9	165.5	169.5	169.4	169.4	169.8	172.9	170.9	173.3	172.2
– discretionary services	154.5	155.1	158.8	160.3	164.8	165.6	167.1	171.8	171.9	171.2	172.3	174.7	173.4	175.9	174.3
– essential services	144.8	149.4	153.5	158.5	161.0	164.0	163.2	166.2	165.8	166.7	166.2	170.3	167.2	169.5	169.1
goods	135.3	136.5	138.5	139.7	142.4	144.4	145.6	147.4	146.6	146.8	148.7	150.3	149.8	151.0	149.0
– discretionary goods	136.3	136.5	139.1	141.8	144.9	145.5	146.6	148.2	148.7	147.9	148.1	148.9	149.0	149.9	146.0
– essential goods	134.4	136.4	138.1	137.9	140.2	143.5	144.8	146.7	144.9	145.9	149.2	151.5	150.5	152.0	151.6
MHSI card index*	142.3	143.3	145.9	147.3	150.5	152.2	153.4	155.8	155.3	155.3	157.0	159.5	158.7	160.1	158.6
qtly%ch	1.2	0.7	1.8	1.0	2.1	1.1	0.8	1.6	1.0	0.7	1.6	1.9	1.8	2.1	2.0
qtly, ann%ch	4.6	2.6	4.1	4.8	5.7	6.2	5.1	5.8	5.2	5.4	5.8	5.7	5.7	5.7	5.7
retail card index*	142.8	143.3	146.0	148.0	151.2	152.0	153.8	155.4	155.7	155.1	155.4	156.4	156.6	157.4	155.1
qtly%ch	1.2	0.4	1.9	1.4	2.2	0.5	1.2	1.1	1.8	1.3	1.1	0.8	0.6	0.5	0.4
qtly, ann%ch	4.2	1.8	4.3	4.9	5.9	6.0	5.3	5.0	5.6	5.3	5.0	4.9	4.7	4.5	4.2
By state															
– NSW	138.3	139.8	142.5	144.2	148.0	148.7	149.2	152.2	151.4	151.4	153.8	156.6	155.8	157.9	154.6
– Vic	136.7	138.6	140.4	142.4	144.9	146.1	147.1	149.9	149.1	150.0	150.7	154.1	153.7	154.9	154.9
– Qld	152.5	155.5	159.2	161.8	167.1	169.8	169.6	174.1	173.5	173.8	174.8	178.1	176.9	178.2	178.7
– WA	153.6	156.7	159.5	163.0	167.7	170.8	171.7	177.5	175.8	177.1	179.5	182.1	181.6	182.7	181.7
– SA	150.1	152.2	154.6	157.0	160.4	162.2	163.0	166.8	165.3	166.7	168.5	168.9	168.6	169.1	168.6

All indexes based on the value of spending–related transactions, seasonally adjusted by Westpac, 2019 avg=100. See p10 for more details.
* composite based on transactions in categories in scope for ABS monthly spending indicator and ABS retail sales surveys respectively.

Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

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About the Westpac card data indicators

The indicators presented in this report are based on the millions of credit and debit card transactions processed every day. Transactions covering over ten million merchants are classified into over 700 categories. These are in turn grouped into higher level aggregates that provide a timely guide to wider economic trends.

The main focus of these indicators is consumer spending. Where possible, we have sought to exclude 'non spending' transactions such as: money transfers; tax payments; loan repayments; charitable donations; and superannuation contributions.

It should also be noted that these indicators will also be affected by shifts between card and non-card transactions. This was a significant factor during the COVID–19 pandemic – health concerns about the use of physical cash leading to significantly higher use of cards vs cash, particularly where contact–less transactions are available. Transaction flows also include reversals/refunds which were also a significant phenomenon during the onset of COVID, especially in areas such as travel.

All transaction data is compiled at a highly aggregated level so that individual customer or merchant data is never revealed.

Index construction

The key metrics used in this report are indexes of spending–related card activity where the base of 100 is average activity in 2019. As an example, if transaction flows are 5% above their average level in 2019, the index read for the period is 105. If flows in a subsequent period are 8% above the average level in 2019, the index read for this period is 108. Growth between the two periods can be calculated simply as the change between the two index reads, i.e. 2.9%.

All measures are adjusted for regular seasonality. Weekly estimates are generated using the US Bureau of Labor's MoveReg weekly seasonal adjustment program. Note that in some cases, high levels of volatility during the COVID period mean it is not possible to produce seasonally adjusted estimates for some historical periods.

Also, note that previous versions of this report used different approaches to seasonal adjustment and measurement more generally. This means Index reads are sometimes not directly comparable. See the 'About the Westpac card data indicators' sections from earlier reports to more detail.

Classifications

Note that the measures used for card data and in this report do not align completely with the those used in official ABS statistics, including the ABS household spending indicator, ABS retail trade survey and ABS estimate of consumer spending published in the national accounts. There are a range of differences including around both coverage and classification. As such, the card data should be treated as broadly indicative.

The transaction data is grouped into 26 categories that are then combined into four main as follows:

Discretionary goods: alcoholic beverages, tobacco, clothing & footwear, furnishings & household equipment, household appliances, vehicle–related, recreational & cultural goods, newspaper, books & stationery, and other personal effects.

Discretionary services: transport services (part), recreational & cultural services, gambling, catering services, accommodation services, other personal care, insurance & financial services, other services.

Essential goods: food & non alcoholic beverages, medical products, appliances & equipment, and operation of personal transport equipment.

Essential services: electricity, gas & other fuels, health services, transport services (part), communications and education.

The report also uses two additional classifications:

MHSI/Retail: based on the extent to which categories cover activity that is in scope for the ABS monthly household spending indicator and ABS retail trade survey.

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